The Future!

Reality Check

Goal: Validate that their anxiety isn't "wrong," it’s a response to a real environment.

1. **Question:** "If you look at the news or think about graduation, what is the one thing that feels like it’s 'shaking' the most right now?"

2. **Question:** "Is it possible to have 100% control over your life? If not, what percentage do you think we actually have?"

3. **Question:** “If you could guarantee one specific thing about your life 10 years from now, would that eliminate all your fear, or just change it?"

4. **The "Past Evidence" File:** "Even if you're only 15 or 17, where has God already shown up for you? How can that 'history' help you trust Him with your college major?"

Transition: "I felt that loss of control when I faced a layoff. I realized adults don't have it all figured out; we just have bigger stakes. But I found that while the 'shaking' is real, the Anchor is more real."

THE Foundation PROMISE: The Hand in the Dark: (Isaiah 41:10–13)

Goal: Establish that God is a Person who is present in history and personal life.

5. **Opening Question:** ”When you’re in a dark room, do you need a lecture on how light works, or someone to just come in and sit with you?"

Scripture: Isaiah 41:10–13 The Old Testament Narrative:
Theme: God as the Steadying Hand in World Turmoil

Notes: Isaiah was writing to a people facing national upheaval, war, and displacement—very similar to the "world turmoil" your teens are

sensing.

Key Verse: *"For I, the Lord your God, hold your right hand; it is I who say to you, 'Fear not, I am the one who helps you.'" (v. 13)*

Study Focus: Use the imagery of the "right hand." In your story about the layoff, you didn't know where the path was going, but you knew *who* was holding your hand. This helps teens shift their focus from the scary "thing" (the news, a school shooting threat, college apps) to the person of God.

6. **Question:** "In verse 13, God says He 'holds your right hand.' If someone is holding your hand, how close do they have to be? Can they hold your hand from across the room or through a screen?"

7. **Question:** "Notice God says, 'I will help you.' Does that mean the problem disappears, or that He’s in the middle of it with you?"

The Truth: You aren't being guided by a map; you’re being guided by a **Person**.

The Image: God isn't shouting directions from a distance. He is "holding your right hand."

Reflection: If God is holding your hand right now, does the "where" of

your future matter as much as the "who" you are with?

The Bridge Statement: "This promise wasn't just for people 3,000 years ago. Because of Jesus, we are part of this same family. This is the 'Warranty' we carry into the future."

The Gospel Anchor (Matthew 6:25–34)

Goal: See how Jesus expands that promise into the "Small Stuff" and "Big Stuff."

8. "How is talking to a friend who has 'been there' different from reading a manual on how to be happy?"

Scripture: *Matthew 6:25–34*

Theme: Prioritizing the Kingdom over the "What-Ifs"

Notes: This is the quintessential text for anxiety because Jesus addresses the most basic human fears (food, clothing, longevity) and scales them up to the "unknowns" of tomorrow.

Key Verse: *"Therefore do not be anxious about tomorrow, for tomorrow will be anxious for itself. Sufficient for the day is its own trouble." (v. 34)*

Study Focus: Help the teens see that God doesn't promise a blueprint of their entire 20s or 30s. Instead, He promises presence for *today*. The "exercise" here is the discipline of presence—focusing on being

faithful in high school right now rather than solving a career crisis that is years away.

9. **Question:** "Jesus talks about birds and flowers. Why do you think He uses nature to talk to people who are worried about their lives and their futures?"

10. **Question:** "Verse 34 says 'tomorrow will be anxious for itself.' Is that a relief to hear, or does it make you more nervous? Why?"

11. **Question:** "Jesus says to 'Seek first the Kingdom.' If you're worried about a math test or a school shooting, what does 'seeking the Kingdom' look like in that exact moment?"

The Truth: Anxiety is usually "living in a future that hasn't happened yet."

The Image: The birds and the lilies don't "hustle" for their worth. They simply exist in God's care.

Reflection: What is one "Tomorrow Problem" you can hand back to

Jesus so you can focus on being faithful **today**?

The Bridge Statement: "Jesus is making the Isaiah promise concrete. He’s saying: 'I am the God who holds your hand, and I’m also the God who knows you need a career and a future.'"

The Prayer of Presence (Psalm 46:1–3, 10)

THE PRACTICE: The Power of Being Still

Goal: Give them a practical "Exercise" to use when the world feels loud.

12. **Opening Question:** “Think of your best friend. Did that friendship happen because of one big event, or a thousand small, boring moments?"

Scripture: *Psalm 46:1–3, 10*

Theme: Finding a Fortress in a Shaking World

Notes: This Psalm is unique because it acknowledges that the earth might literally "give way" and the "mountains move into the heart of the sea." It doesn't minimize the chaos of the world; it places God above it.

Key Verse: *"Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth!" (v. 10)*

Study Focus: The Hebrew word for "be still" (*raphah*) can also mean "let go" or "surrender." This ties directly into your personal example. The struggle isn't just "not worrying"; it's the active spiritual exercise of "letting go" of the need to control the outcome and "resting" in God’s sovereignty.

13. **Question:** "The Psalm describes the earth 'giving way' and mountains falling into the sea. When you hear about wars or divisions in the world, does it feel like the mountains are falling?"

14. **Question:** "Verse 10 says 'Be still.' In a world that tells you to 'hustle' or 'worry' to get ahead, why is being still so difficult? Is it a passive thing or an active choice?"

The Truth: Faith is an **exercise**. We don't just "have" it; we "do" it.

The Image: A Fortress. When the earth shakes, the Fortress doesn't move.

The Exercise: *Selah* (Pause). Take 60 seconds of silence. Use the phrase: *"Be still, and know that I am God."*

The Bridge Statement: "This isn't just a poem; it's a practice. When I was looking for a job, I had to 'be still' and remember that God is God,

and I am not. That is where the peace comes from—knowing the Person who is in charge."

The Takeaway

Goal: Commit to one "Exercise of Faith."

15. **Question:** Do you already have a practice that you find helpful for reminding yourself of God’s promises when tough times strike, or fear and anxiety flood your emotions?

16. **Final Question:** "This week, when that 'shaking' feeling starts in your chest—whether it's about a college app or a news headline—which of these three images do you want to grab onto: The Hand (Isaiah), The Bird (Matthew), or The Fortress (Psalm)?"

Why Christianity is Different

We don't just follow a philosophy or a set of "good vibes." We have a relationship with **Jesus Christ**—God incarnate. Through the **Holy Spirit**, He is literally *with you* in the hallway, the classroom, and the quiet of your room. He isn't just watching you; He is walking with you.

My "Evidence" File

Adults don't have all the answers, but we have "History." Think of one

time in the past when things felt scary, but God showed up or carried you through. Write it here to remind yourself that He is faithful:

[ ]

This Week's Challenge:

When the "shaking" starts—when you feel that knot of anxiety about school, the news, or your family—stop for 10 seconds. Visualize God holding your right hand (Isaiah 41:13) and say: **"Lord, I don't know the future, but I know You."**

Question Corral

17. What weakness that you confront daily can remind you to rely on God as your source of strength?

18. What does it mean when the Lord says, 'Fear not, for I am with you'? How does this relate to our everyday lives?

19. How do you see God demonstrating His strength and help in your life or the lives of those around you?

20. In what ways do you think God’s assurance of 'upholding' and 'strengthening' us impacts our experience of fear or anxiety?

21. What action steps can you take this week to lean into God's strength, especially when facing challenges?

22. How can prayer play a role in helping us internalize the reassurance found in this passage?

23. What are some practical ways you can remind yourself of God's strength when you feel overwhelmed?

24. How can scripture play a role in helping us internalize the reassurance found in this passage?